of others to participate in it. Their willingness depended on their strategic priorities and their perception of India's importance relative to others in their own strategies. Thus, for example, India could use a diversified Soviet-US balance against China only as long as both the Soviet Union and the US sought to balance China with India. When Washington's China policy changed and it sought to engage rather than contain China, this option was no longer available to India. In a crisis, India then had to tilt toward the Soviet Union, signing a treaty that it had earlier resisted.

There is always the danger that, as the Soviet Union did in 1962 and the US did in 1971, a strategic partner will choose an existing or desired ally, for example China, over a friend, such as India. At other times of crisis, as this book shows, external actors chose not to participate in India's diversification strategy because they did not want to take sides, or because they disapproved of an Indian course of action. This was the case during the 1965 India-Pakistan war, when India found itself needing external assistance and reassurance vis-à-vis China, but getting only limited equipment from the Soviet Union and being unsure about what it could expect from the US.

Ends, Ways, and Means

Today, we are once again discussing the China effect on US-India relations, and the focus often tends to be on the question of whether and to what extent it will bring the two democracies together. This book shows that it can do so; it also demonstrates that it is not a given—even when both the US and India see China as a threat. Indeed, China might keep them apart. In the period that this book covers, India and the US did partner when China appeared to pose a threat. However, the two countries partnered against a Chinese threat only when they agreed on (1) the nature of the threat, (2) the urgency of the threat, and (3) how to deal with the threat.

On the other hand, disagreements on threat perception and on the approach to take toward China had an adverse impact on the US-India relationship, often driving the two countries apart. Differences on approach involved differing ideas of (1) how other actors such as Pakistan and the Soviet Union fit in to their China strategies, (2) what the best policy instruments were to deal with the China conundrum (e.g., force, diplomacy,